India’s prime minister attends. The frequency of finance ministers and governors meetings went up to four per year during the peak of the crisis in 2009 and 2010, but has since reverted to the standard pattern of two meetings every year.

The chair of the G20 rotates every year from one member country to another. All the G20 meetings are typically held in, and hosted by, the chair country. The chair country takes the lead in formulating and driving the agenda and providing logistic and secretarial support. The president of the World Bank and the managing director of the IMF also attend the G20 meetings, thereby ensuring that the activities of the G20 are integrated into the agenda of the Bretton Woods institutions where necessary. There are also other invitees such as the OECD, UNDP and the regional development banks like the Asian Development Bank.

The G20 was in the forefront of battling the global financial crisis of 2008–09. Indeed, when the history of this crisis is written, the London G20 Summit in April 2009 will be acknowledged as the clear turning point when world leaders showed extraordinary determination and unity in addressing the biggest economic and financial crisis of our time. There were differences, of course, but they were debated and discussed, and compromises were made in order to attain the shared goal of restoring market confidence. In fact, the entire range of crisis-response measures—accommodative monetary stance, fiscal stimulus, debt and deposit guarantees, capital injection, asset purchases, currency swaps—all derived in varying degrees from G20 decisions.

The sense of purpose and vaunted unity that the G20 had shown in managing the crisis all through 2009 and 2010 started dissipating in 2011 as the agenda shifted from crisis response to agreeing on post-crisis reforms. The fault lines ran along several dimensions: between advanced and emerging economies over the responsibility of the former for the spillover impact of their policies that were adversely impacting the emerging markets; between America and Europe on the management of the eurozone sovereign debt crisis; and largely between America and the rest of the world on banking regulation reforms that eventually led to the Basel III standards.